her low and vulgar protectors'. Women became satis mostly among upper-caste Hindus, especially warrior elites, who appeared more often in Bernier's milieu. Notably,

> . . . the Mahometans, by whom the country is governed, [do] all in their power to suppress the barbarous custom. They do not, indeed, forbid it by a positive law, because it is a part of their policy to leave the idolatrous population, which is so much more numerous than their own, in the free exercise of its religion; but the practice is checked by indirect means. No woman can sacrifice herself without permission from the governor of the province in which she resides, and he never grants it until he shall have ascertained that she is not to be turned aside from her purpose: to accomplish this desirable end the governor reasons with the widow and makes her enticing promises; after which, if these methods fail, he sometimes sends her among his women, that the effect of their remonstrances may be tried. Notwithstanding these obstacles, the number of self-immolations is still very considerable, particularly in the territories of the [Rajput] Rajas, where no Mahometan governors are appointed.

Tavernier too notes the official restraints Bernier describes above. A woman, Tavernier writes, 'cannot burn herself with the body of her husband without having received permission from the Governor of the place where she dwells, and those Governors who are Muhammadans, hold this dreadful custom of self-destruction in horror, and do not readily give permission'. It is then curious, writes Romila Thapar, that in the nineteenth century people would start believing that sati 'was necessitated by the "Muslim invasions" when upper-caste Hindu women had to defend their honour from Muslim marauders'.[5] In fact, the first-known cases of sati in India date from mid-first millennium BCE, long before the birth of Islam.[6]

Bernier refuses to believe, as some apologists of sati claim, that 'an excess of affection was the cause why these women burn themselves with their deceased husbands'. He believes it's 'the effect of early and deeply rooted prejudices'. 'Every girl is taught by her mother that it is virtuous and laudable in a wife to mingle her ashes with those of her husband, and that no woman of honour will refuse compliance with the established custom. These opinions men have always inculcated as an easy mode of keeping wives in subjection, of securing their attention in times of sickness, and of deterring them from administering poison to their husbands.'

Bernier also expresses his dislike for the 'endless variety of Fakires, or Derviches, and Holy Men, or Gentile hypocrites of the Indies'. He speaks of a group 'seated or lying on ashes, entirely naked [with] hair hanging down